



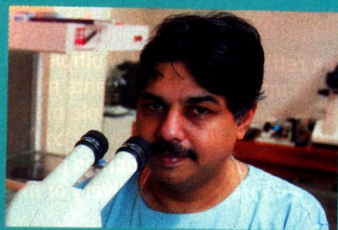
"Motherhood is every woman's dream but fertility treatments can be humiliating."

DR FIRUZA PARIKH, DIRECTOR,
DEPARTMENT OF ASSISTED REPRODUCTION AND GENETICS,
JASLOK HOSPITAL, MUMBAI



"Of the 200 million people in their reproductive age in India, 10 per cent are infertile."

DR HRSHIKESH PAI
GYNAECOLOGIST AND INFERTILITY SPECIALIST AT LILAVATI
HOSPITAL, MUMBAI AND BATRA HOSPITAL, DELHI



► **FARAH KHAN, 42, DIRECTOR.** She is pregnant with triplets right now.

TREATMENT Underwent IUI and one cycle of IVF. The IUI cycle failed because of stress during filming.

tion has increased from 248 in 2001 to 641 in 2006." Partly as a consequence of this, the number of IVF treatment cycles has gone up, from 7,273 in 2001 to 19,005 in 2005, according to the National A.R.T. (Artificial Reproduction Technology) Registry of India—in the UK, the corresponding figure is 27,000 IVF cycles every year. Hrshikesh Pai, gynaecologist and infertility specialist at Lilavati Hospital, Mumbai, and Batra Hospital, Delhi, agrees, having seen a 30 per cent annual increase in the number of patients coming for IVF.

There is a realisation now that late motherhood or even infertility is not a stigma. As Imogen Edwards-Jones, who wrote *The Stork Club*, chronicling her battle to conceive with IVF, said in

The Guardian: "Until recently, fertility treatment was barely discussed, like some embarrassing secret that one was incapable of having a baby. Many people on IVF still keep it a secret because they feel they have failed, and to be seen to fail, and to do it so obviously, is not part of our culture. Neither is waiting—today, if you want it, you buy it, but with IVF, you need enormous patience." But increasingly infertility is being seen as "normal". After all, data shows that even if a couple between the ages of 20 and 25 has intercourse daily for a month, only 17 per cent, in this category, will conceive in a month, 40 per cent will conceive in three months, 60 per cent in six months and 80 per cent in one year. The fertility declines

with each passing year, down to 2 per cent by the age of 45.

The cost of assisted reproduction ranges anywhere from Rs 60,000 to Rs 1.2 lakh for one cycle (on an average it takes at least two cycles). There is also a high risk of multiple children—with four to five embryos implanted during every cycle, the risk of conceiving quadruplets is 0.7 per cent, triplets is 4.5 per cent and twins is 24.4 per cent (NARI, 2005). Yet it is less expensive than in the West, where it ranges from \$10,000-15,000 (Rs 3.98-5.97 lakh) per cycle, which is what drove 35-year-old Bejal Nirav Shah to India. The Mumbai-based homemaker got married at 25 and never thought her wait for a child would last nine years. "I was in New